

CLAUDE CODE

Claude Code 16: The Memory Foam Mattress Theory of Claude Code

Plus a beautiful deck describing my workflow



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I've been watching friends try to onboard to Claude Code lately. [Pedro Sant'Anna](#) has a beautiful workflow system with orchestrators and agents and quality gates. [Antor Mele](#) made a curated skill marketplace organized by research stage. Both are genuinely useful.

But I'm not sure that it's what people need to start out, despite the fact that they are both in that old tradition online of being "starter kits" or "best of lists". And I want to tell you why. And to do it, I'm going to talk about some economics jargon, and I'm going to give you a theory of Claude Code I have which is Claude Code is a foam mattress that you have to sleep on a while, let it conform to you, and only then will you sleep well through the night.

Three Similar Economics Concepts Before We Get Started

But then before we get into my memory foam theory of Claude Code, I want to set the stage and present the current state of affairs to you as it relates to Claude Code. I have said this before and I want to say it one more time. There are various similar ideas

economics I want to present to help you understand CC adoption right now. And there are these:

- incumbents vs entrants
- average user vs marginal user
- intensive margin vs extensive margin

They don't mean the same thing, *per se*, but I'm going to use them as if they are the same thing because I think maybe this can help some of you reading this figure out where you fit in the scheme of this. I think if you're reading this, you are almost certainly more likely to be the entrant than the incumbent; you are more likely to be the marginal user than the average user; and you are more likely to be in the extensive margins of demand than the intensive ones.

In simple firm competition games, you often will have some firm who got there first and someone else who is thinking of entering. These games are intrinsically about competition with one another, and in that sense the metaphor isn't super helpful for understanding Claude Code adoption. I don't think you or I are in competition with software engineers over the use of Claude Code, but nonetheless I think the metaphor is helpful because it represents the fact that for probably 16 months there has been a group of Claude Code users called "software engineers" or "computer scientists" who work for a living, producing products for firms that are sold in product markets. They provide labor in input markets, paid wages, which they use to buy products produced and sold by firms. Their work is valuable to the firm who produces goods and services valued by households. The famous circular flow diagram in economics we typically teach in our principles classes on the first day of class.

Well, let's face it. If you are reading this, you're most likely a PhD or aspiring PhD in the applied social sciences like economics, political science, education, law, accounting, sociology, and the like. You may also be in the qualitative ones too. I actually think Claude Code is perfect for anyone whose work lives inside "director-

on their computer” — whose projects are in some sense **the folders** even. I mean, is that in one sense what research is? Research is folders. Teaching is folders. Sure, it’s more than that obviously, but it’s stored on computers. All the knowledge associated with research and teaching lives in a series of directories, folders and branches that exist inside of a series of 0s and 1s on our computer which we navigate via a conceptual model that is a hierarchy of folders. And that is really who Claude Code is for. Claude Code is for anyone whose work lives in a hierarchy of folders and directories. Which means what exactly? That **Claude Code is for everyone** because just described everyone!

But, here’s the problem — it’s just about one of the most alien types of software any of us has ever encountered because this is not your parent’s software. It is not really exogenous in nature. It’s very fluid, it’s very malleable, it’s adaptive. It’s like water. I like trying to code with water. And so understandably, it’s weird and no one really can even comprehend what that means, because they have no frame of reference and the writings of incumbents, mostly engineers at this point, is not terribly useful, or at least doesn’t seem to be, because the words are different, and the tasks described don’t even seem close to what you do on a daily basis except for one word — code. And even then you don’t often recognize the coding in what is being described.

So that’s what I mean by incumbent vs entrant. All of us here I think are the entrants and most if not all of the writings about Claude Code are by incumbents. Even when it’s social scientists, if you look closely, it’s usually selecting on the more hard core coders of the set of social scientists there is. So even then, you may feel like you’re listening to someone from your tribe, but who had always been one of the more technical persons from your tribe, explaining things that you still can’t understand.

And that is because right now, the average writer and the average user of Claude Code remains in that programmer/engineer/computer scientist set of incumbents. And you and I probably are the marginal users, the entrants, the extensive margin set of demand. We are *coming in* to Claude Code, and it’s not clear how to do it for most of

the extensive margin because by definition, the extensive margin is different than the intensive margin in one important way — the intensive margin group of users are already there, already selected in based on some innate characteristic that the extensive margin who isn't there yet doesn't possess. Maybe it's some shadow price that for the intensive margin was always already very low, but for the extensive margin was always very very high. Which leads me to my next point.

There is no onramp

I'm going to make a bold claim. The thing about Claude Code that nobody's written yet, or maybe wants to admit, is that there is no real onramp to using Claude Code productively — to using it as a real labor enhancing tool. Not really. And here's why

I have had trouble sleeping for a decade now. It started out because of anxiety problems due to family stuff. Long story, not important. But then that stuff wasn't there anymore, but the sleep problems remained. Which made me wonder — was the family stuff masking some unobserved variable and that all along it had been that, or it aging or something, that had been the problem?

My ex-wife was so good at picking stuff out. Picking out the furniture, picking out the colors, the paint, the house even. The food, the restaurants, the music, the ambiance. She was — is — elegant, classy, thoughtful, and just patient. She knew what she liked and was willing to wait until she found it. Which drove me crazy sometimes because we'd wait and wait and wait on important things like a couch. But then when that couch got here, wow. That really was the perfect couch. And I think we made a good team because I actually had no opinion at all in the process so long as I could get my work done.

Well, it was like that with the mattress. I never had trouble sleeping on our mattress because she was a wizard at finding that mattress. But see I am impulsive. When I

with a ton of options, I take the first one. I want it over with. And it's basically the right decision in ... never. It never works. So when we got divorced, and I was living my own, I had to buy a mattress, and I knew this was a problem, so I had anticipate problem and solve it. I knew that I had no idea how to ex ante pick a mattress. I couldn't anticipate what I needed or wanted until I had it, and hated it and wanted return it. So I just took the easy way out — I bought a mattress made of **memory foam**.

I got the memory foam because I didn't know what I needed, and I didn't know what I wanted, except that I wanted to sleep. That's all I knew. And memory foam seemed appealing precisely because **memory foam is endogenous**. It endogenous material. Endogenous to what? It is endogenous to me. To my body shape. To my style of sleeping. And so here's the thing that memory foam does — it learns. It listens. **It pays attention to me**. And that's how it is successful.

Claude Code is a memory foam mattress. It is not a preconceived exogenous piece of software. And the reason this is important to know is because every other piece of software you have ever used had rules. It was exogenous. When you said "I want to learn R", what did you mean? You meant I wanted to learn packages, and ways of thinking, a certain programming language logic. Because if you could learn that programming language logic, then you could learn the skills, and then you could perform the tasks that only could done with that language, by you. I call that **exogenous software**.

Claude Code is not exogenous software. Claude Code is not a firm mattress. Claude Code is not a soft mattress. Claude Code is an endogenous mattress, it is memory foam, it is endogenous software, it conforms to you, it adapts to your style, not the other way around.

And I think that is why it confuses people, maybe intimidates them even. But if I'm right, and I am right, then what it means is that you cannot take another person's starter kit because the fact is another person's starter kit is based on their shape, their body, their style of work. There is no such thing as a "correct shape" in the memory

foam of a mattress. The correct shape in the memory of a memory foam mattress is shape that formed that held your body so well that you slept through the night.

And Claude Code — what no one really understands, I think — is so endogenous, so malleable, to how you work that not only do the average users not really understand what the marginal users need — I don't even think Anthropic, who made Claude Code, fully understand this.

There really is no substitute then for this. No one can teach you to use Claude Code to become productive in your research and teaching. There's nothing to teach! There's "prompt engineering" with Claude Code — frankly, there never was any prompt engineering with chatbots either. Prompt engineering is like when someone is trying to teach people how to have conversations on a date. Sure, I guess there is such a thing, but it requires far, far more skill at having a conversation with a real person than it does with LLMs, because LLMs are like the Mister Rogers of software. They are so good at listening and paying attention that you can misspell and babble and go on unnecessary tangents, and they still somehow figure out what you are trying to say. I don't think that's prompt engineering — I think that's LLMs just being LLMs and being really good at it.

It's the same with Claude Code. You just have to use it, you just have to trust that it's in the limit — and trust me, you reach that long run limiting point within no time, seriously — it will figure you out. That's the thing — it won't be you figuring out Claude Code. It'll be Claude Code figuring you out! So you just have to do it. You don't start with starter kits. You start with **directories**. I mean it! You start with this:

Please look around this directory and tell me what the hell is going on in here. It looks like a hoarder's nest! Please help me make this deck of slides for my class! I'm overwhelmed with work. Use beamer, and install it if it's not installed. I don't even know how to use that frankly. Do the whole thing for me. I am anxious about the class, and I am anxious about the research project, and I am anxious about you. I need help. So please make a beautiful, beautiful deck based on this chapter, on the

thing we're doing in class, and here — here's last year's exams, here's last year's homework. Here's a couple of papers. Just please read them, and come up with a beautiful deck. Make my life easier, not harder. I am living on my budget constraint and if you can help me, I will really appreciate it.

That is how you use Claude Code. I know I sound like a cult leader. But I'm not. I am just someone who finally started to sleep through the night after years of sleepless nights.

/insights

When I say something dramatic like “Claude Code changed my life”, the surprising thing is that I actually mean it. I know I mean it because I have been using it nearly nonstop since mid November. You know the proof I have too? I typed this into Claude Code yesterday:

```
/insights
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When you type in `/insights` into Claude Code, it analyzes the last six weeks of your work. Gives you a report on what's working, and what isn't working. I did that, and produced an interactive html, but I don't think in terms of html. I think in terms of decks because decks tell stories. So I asked Claude Code to make my `/insights` into a “beautiful deck” that followed “the rhetoric of decks” philosophy I have outlined in my MixtapeTools repo. And I'm going to share it. This is *my workflow*, and it's apparently based on the impossibly high number of **1,642 hours** of use. That number cannot be right because that would mean I have been using Claude Code for something like 70 full days since its release on the Mac desktop app in November! And yet when I think about it, I have been burning 14 hour days for months getting classes together, finishing major projects that were dying on the vine, and meeting deadlines.

— at a level of productivity I have never had, not on this sustained level. All while managing to hang out with some friends here in Boston. (It’s also possible it’s countless things I’ve been running in parallel though).

The Intellectual Production System

A Portrait in 57 Sessions

57	702	1,642	30
sessions	messages	hours	commits

Scott Cunningham · Claude Code /Insights · February 2026

So, here’s my deck description of how I work — this is Claude Code’s interpretation of how I work, and what he suggests I do differently going forward. It is **purely** a description of my mattress though. Yours will be different, and yours will be perfect for you.



Insights Deck
196KB · PDF file

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What this means for learning Claude Code

If the mattress conforms to you, then that means every person's starter kit is just a reflection of their manifestation of the Claude Code workflow that worked for them. It's like when someone gives you advice on how to study for exams, and the advice is to use 16 different colored markers. And you're like, "okay I'm color blind but I guess I'm going to try this." And unsurprisingly, it doesn't work.

I'm not saying don't use starter kits. I'm saying that in the long run, your workflow will be Claude Code and you working so intensively together on tasks towards success that it's almost as if you aren't using a preexisting software anymore as much as you are using the software that you and Claude Code invented together. There won't be "learning R". There will be "this is how I work, this is what works for me, this is how I have managed to become successful at my job using Claude Code". And for some it looks one way, and for others it looks another way, and neither is right, and neither is wrong.

The sinking into the memory foam on my side of the bed is just that — it's my side of the bed. It's my shell. No one else could probably even sleep there successfully until that memory foam "forgot" my body. The shell is not transferable. What's transferable is the *idea that the mattress will conform to you and your style of work*. You just have to try it and trust me.

Why story works and documentation doesn't

This is why I write the way I write about Claude Code the way that I do. I think you just have to see someone using it. The guerrilla series, the videos, the real-time fumbling around. The more you see it, the more confident you'll feel that it's easy, not hard.

I'm not on here trying to teach a tool to readers because I literally think there is no such thing as that. I just want to illustrate to you the way that the people who sell

memory foam say that it works. They just say “lay down in it for a few weeks”.

People at the extensive margin don’t need a workflow diagram. It won’t help them anyway. I think the main thing that helps is to watch someone fumble through it, using it for the types of tasks they do every day. That’s what will help. And that’s so much more than documentation. I think that’s how you unlock the door to the extensive margin. Not through starter kits and documentation — let other people see you lying down on it, and they’ll get it. They’ll figure it out so long as they jump in.

So many things are like that. So many things cannot be taught; they can only be learned. Claude Code cannot be taught. Using AI Agents for work cannot be taught; it can only be learned. So I encourage you to do that.



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Discussion about this post

Comments

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Scientist 2d

♥ Liked by [scott cunningham](#)

Fun post, but – isn’t it a little too on-brand for an economist to say “the engineers’ jargon isn’t helpful” and then immediately explain it with “incumbents vs entrants, marginal users, and extensive margin”?

If anyone should be numb to professional lingo by now, it's the people who turned "it depends" dialect.

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2 replies by scott cunningham and others



Ted Roberts 2d Edited

♡ Liked by scott cunningham

I think you may be underestimating the value of starter kits for us newbies. I am a non-coding lawyer who has just started experimenting with Claude Code, both through the desktop app and Mac's Terminal. Most of the skills featured in your links are probably inapplicable to what lawyers do on a daily basis. But lawyers, like economists, devote a lot of time to research, reading and reviewing "literature" (for lawyers, that would be case law, statutes, and secondary materials), and also producing written work-product that follows fairly predictable patterns (e.g., correspondence, legal documents, contracts, long-form legal briefs). As far as I can tell, few lawyers are both using and sharing their experiences with Claude Code. Therefore, I find it very helpful to read accounts by knowledgeable people describing how they are using it. My own hunch about what a good "starter kit" involves probably begins outside of AI: decomposing one's work into individual tasks.

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1 reply by scott cunningham

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